

Winning the Day at the PICL Rally 2026

PARENTS & COACHES

What is a PICL Rally?

A **PICL Rally** is a mountain bike race format inspired by enduro-style racing. Student-athletes ride one lap of their course from start to finish. Along the way, they will encounter designated race segments where their time will be recorded.

Why a PICL Rally?

The Rally format gives us the flexibility to race in places that may not be well suited for a traditional XC course by racing select segments of the trail instead. It also gives student-athletes the opportunity to discover and showcase different strengths, while allowing us to explore new venues, bring events closer to home, and keep events and courses fresh, fun, and exciting.

Race Segments

As a rider arrives at a race segment, a volunteer will stop them and provide instructions. The volunteer will then count down to “go” and the rider will begin to race. Once the rider reaches the end of the race segment, another volunteer will slow them down to indicate the race segment is finished. A rider will encounter 3 or 4 race segments during their ride, depending on their race category.

Non-Race Segments

The non-race segments are referred to as transitions. Students ride the transitions at a relaxed pace, taking in the scenery and enjoying the company of other riders along the way. During the transitions, riders will recover, hydrate, fuel, and pace themselves in preparation for the next race segment. The transitions are not for racing and do not count toward the student's overall time.

Timing and Scoring

After racing has concluded, a student-athlete's race segment times are added up to give them their overall time. For scoring, the riders are ranked in order of fastest to slowest overall time within their race category.

Due to the timing method utilized for PICL Rally events, times and scoring will not be available live. Instead, times and scores will be communicated post-event.

What if a student-athlete has a mechanical?

If the mechanical is repairable, Rolling Coaches will be available to provide the rider with support. If the mechanical is beyond repair, see the answer to the next question. No penalties will be applied for mechanical support provided during non-race segments. Penalties will apply in race segments (see PA Handbook for details).

What if a student-athlete cannot finish?

If that student is just uninterested in finishing the course or has a mechanical that is beyond repair, they will need to wait patiently at a finish line of a segment and will be brought back as able by a Roving Marshal.

What if a student-athlete gets injured on the course?

Just like in all our PICL races, Roving Marshals and a Medical Quick Responder will be on-site and ready to implement standard injury protocols.

What if we see a Sasquatch?

My understanding is that they appreciate a good party so invite them along for the ride. This is an unknown fact, but as they originally evolved in the Pacific Northwest, they can rip, and most have a bike hiding somewhere in the brush close by.

Coaches Can Set Their Athletes Up For Success

→ The Rally is different from a traditional XC race, so it is important that student-athletes understand that they are not racing the entire course.

→ Student-athletes ride the full length of their course, but only the race segments contribute to their overall time. The non-race segments should not be raced. Instead, they should be used to recover and prepare for the next race segment.

→ Riders will need to manage their energy throughout the Rally. Going all-out on the first race segment may make it harder to perform well on the following race segments.

→ The Rally format rewards riders who can combine fitness with good cornering, braking, descending, climbing, line choice, and overall bike handling.

RACE SEGMENT HOST

Thank you for hosting a race segment. You're part of the team with Rolling Coaches and Roving Marshals - together you're the league's eyes and ears on the course. Each race segment volunteer should fill out [this waiver](#) if they have not done so this season.

Race Segment Start

Supplies: 1 clip board, 2 pens, hand jamming sheets, clock & stand, copy of Winning the Day Guide, 1 team radio

Three (3) volunteers

- Captain
 - Start riders at ~ 30 second intervals. "Racer ready...5 - 4 - 3 - 2 - 1 - GO!"
 - If your line starts to back up, shorten to 20 second intervals.
 - Riders can start the segment in any order.
 - Ensure riders do not get close to the red timing box before starting their race segment.
 - Record plate # & start time for each rider.

- First Mate
 - Make sure that the on-deck rider is ready to go. Rider on bike - check! Helmet on - check! Shoes tied - check!
 - Support the Captain with recording plate # & start time for each rider.
- Skipper
 - Keep riders engaged while they wait at the start of the race segment. A library of conversation starters (list below) and silly jokes is a plus!

Race Segment Finish

Supplies: 1 clip board, 2 pens, hand jamming sheets, clock & stand, copy of Winning the Day Guide, 1 team radio, 1 league marshal radio

Two (2) volunteers

- Admiral
 - Record plate # & finish time for each rider.
 - Ensure riders do not get close to the red box after finishing their race segment.
- Cadet
 - Support the Admiral with recording plate # & start time for each rider.
- Steward
 - Slow riders down after they've passed the end of the race segment & remind them that transitions are not for racing.
 - Serve as Stationary Marshal - communicate with Lead Marshal
 - No penalties will be applied for mechanical support provided during non-race segments. Penalties will apply for high school students in race segments.
 - If there is an injury in your segment, communicate with the Lead Marshal via marshal radio and hold riders at the start line until given the all clear or instructed otherwise. If radio communication is limited in your area, use a cell to call the Lead Marshal.

Conversation Starters

- Who has the closest birthday?
- Who has the most siblings?
- Who is an only child?
- Who has the most pets?
- Who has the most unique pet?
- What's your favorite color? Movie? Song?
- Who is willing to sing a song? Dance?
- Who has the best [clean] joke?
- What was your favorite race this year / why?
- Who has accidentally farted in school? Tried to blame another person? Did it work?
- Favorite Vacation Spot
- Who has been outside the country?
- Who has been to the most unique place?
- Who has been to the most continents?

- What is your favorite piece of gear?
- What is your dream mountain bike?
- What would you say to a friend is your favorite thing about NICA?
- What teams are present?
- What is one thing that you love about your team?
- Sock-Sock-Shoe-Shoe or Sock-Shoe-Sock-Shoe?
- Favorite food? Favorite dessert?
- Favorite post-ride food/drink? Favorite crunchy snack?
- Weirdest thing that you like to eat for a snack
- Who is the funniest person you know? Why?

ROLLING COACHES

Rolling Coaches will be released onto the course at regular intervals. As you ride from start to finish, your role is to float between riders in your area. You can pass, you can be passed. You're part of the team with the race segment volunteers and Roving Marshals - together you're the league's eyes and ears on the course. [SIGN UP HERE TO BE A ROLLING COACH!](#)

As you ride, check in to make sure student-athletes are drinking, eating, and handling it all well. Keep 'em safe. Keep it fun. If they are talking, smiling, laughing, we are all winning. Let kids be kids -- and if there is a teachable moment out there, help them learn.

Carry In Your Pack

- First aid supplies (Level 2 & 3 Coaches)
- Water & snacks (maybe even something fun for the volunteers, if you're so inclined?)
- Spare tube, multi-tool, inflation device
- Cell phone

Race Segments

- Space yourself out from other Rolling Coaches.
- Introduce yourself to race segment volunteers.
- Communicate any issues with the race segment volunteers, who will then communicate with each other and the Lead Marshal.
- When it's your turn on a racing segment, start immediately (and safely) following a rider so that you allow as much time as possible for the rider behind you.

Mechanical Support

If mechanical support is needed, you may provide it. No penalties will be applied for mechanical support provided during non-race segments. Penalties will apply in race segments (see PA Handbook for details). If the mechanical is beyond repair, see below.

Student-Athlete Can't Finish

If a student is uninterested in finishing the course or has a mechanical that is beyond repair, accompany them to the nearest race segment finish line and tell the race segment volunteer. The student will wait there for an escort from a Roving Marshal.

Student-Athlete Is Injured

If there is an injury, address it to the level of your first aid training (Level 2 & 3 Coaches). If additional medical support is needed, communicate as follows:

1. Alert a Roving Marshal (indicated by marshal plate & vest)
Or...
2. Alert a Race Segment Volunteer
Or...
3. Call the Lead Marshal via cell.

You are never far away from a race segment. If you find that you need to go backward in the transition to get help, do so with caution. Refrain from going backward within a race segment.